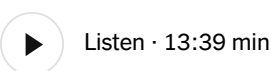


Inside Jeffrey Epstein's Push to Cleanse His Past Online

After he left jail in 2009, Mr. Epstein hired a host of people to make him look better on Google, Wikipedia and many other places on the web.



By Tiffany Hsu and Ken Bensinger

March 18, 2026

An email sent to Jeffrey Epstein in September 2010 presented an intriguing opportunity. “Would you be interested,” it read, “in having all that crap that comes up on Google search on your name basically disappear?”

Mr. Epstein had been released from jail about a year earlier after a conviction for sex crimes involving a minor. His online reputation was a shambles. Less than two hours after receiving the email, he responded:

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“Yes.”

That helped kick-start a yearslong quest by Mr. Epstein to overhaul his online reputation, according to a New York Times review of thousands of pages of emails, financial records and other records released by the Justice Department. The documents make clear that Mr. Epstein became deeply invested in hiding his criminal past in Google searches and on Wikipedia.

He never fully sanitized his web presence before he was arrested again, in 2019, and charged with sex trafficking. But the effort at times allowed Mr. Epstein to maintain an air of respectability and preserve social contacts he might have lost had his crimes been more prominent online.

To accomplish that, Mr. Epstein first turned to the author of the 2010 email — Al Seckel, a professed expert on optical illusions who was in a romantic relationship with an older sister of Chisloine Maxwell, Mr. Epstein’s longtime associate. Over time, a rotating cast of friends